

ABOUT THE SUMMIT

Two Fireside conversations will be moderated by Aaron Kaufman, Maryland state Delegate and Disability rights advocate featuring Michael Toobin, Esq., Dr. Mark Coles, Jeff McKay, Chairman, Fairfax County Board of Supervisors, and members of Congress tba!

Panel 1 – Biases “Challenging Limiting Narratives – Undoing Ablism, Implicit Bias, and Outdated Assumptions”

Moderator: Cortney Heykoop, CEO of Clover Leaf Wealth Strategies

Panelists

1. **Debi Alexander, Esq.**, CEO SPARC
2. **Jerry Hulick**, nationally recognized leader financial services and advocacy for individuals with disabilities, member of United Cerebral Palsy National Board of Trustees, principal and consultant with Caring Consulting Group, and Founder of the Washington Group Special Care
3. **Dr. Nicci Dowd**, Assistant Director of Education, Marymount University
4. **Merrill Friedman**, Regional Vice President, Inclusive Policy and Advocacy, Elevance Health

THE GEORGE
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EVENT DETAILS

July 27, 2026 • 10:00 AM

Jack Morton Auditorium
The George Washington University

Panel 2 - Health Care – “Barriers to Equitable Healthcare Access”

Moderator: Senator Kannan Srinivasan, Virginia State Senator, served in the Virginia House of Delegates on the Health and Human Services Committee and past Board Chair of the Virginia Department of Medical Assistance Services

Panelists

1. **Jessica Bonness**, Professor of Art and Design, Marymount University
2. **Dr. Kevin O'Connor**, GW faculty - School of Medicine and Health Sciences and Adjunct Associate Professor in Health, Human Function and Rehabilitation Sciences
3. **Hannah Irsfeld, Esq.** General Council NOVA, Vice Chair of SPARC, and expert on Medicaid reform
4. **Dr. Megan Mahowald**, Marymount University, Program Director of the Speech-Language Pathology graduate program



Panel 3 – Reforms, Innovations and Bold Imagination - “Designing a Future that Includes Us”

Moderator: Senator Barbara Fravola, Virginia State Senator - Chair Rehabilitation and Social Services Committee, Member Finance and Appropriations, Education and Health, Courts of Justice and Rules

Panelists

1. **Dr. Bonnielinn Swenor**, Endowed Professor of Disability Health and Justice and Director of the Johns Hopkins University Health Research Center
2. **Dr. Qing Zeng**, Director of the Biomedical Informatics Center and a Professor in the Department of Clinical Research and Leadership, George Washington University School of Medicine and Health Sciences
3. **Jamie Dyke**, Licensed Clinical Social Worker, Learning Manager, Center of Excellence, Elevance Health, and member of the Culpeper Town Council



Learn more about ADA Compliance



Tickets are \$50 per attendee, with a discounted rate of \$10 for students. Seats are limited so register today!

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Sponsorship reflects a shared commitment to designing a future that expands dignity and possibility for some of our most isolated individuals.



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Dignity is not a privilege

*—
it's a right.*

CALL FOR PROPOSALS

Share your research, insights, and innovations at the 2026 SPARC Summit with George Washington University!

Submit a 200–300 word abstract on: limiting narratives, systemic barriers, universal design, health equity, or any relevant topic.

Deadline: April 27, 2026

Submit abstracts to:
BIC@gwu.edu

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SPARC / GW SUMMIT 2026

A Call to Conscience

Advancing Dignity for Adults with
Severe and Multiple Disabilities

July 27, 2026

10:00 AM

Jack Morton Auditorium • GW



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KEYNOTE BY

Senator Tim Kaine

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